

GEB 7365 · The MNE beyond the market

Study pack: Caprar 2022 · Bruijn 2024 · Thams 2025 · Sun 2021

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The thread through all four

Each paper argues that international business research has studied the MNE too narrowly, and each names the same three blind spots:

- **Context is under-specified.** "Fit with local culture" (Caprar), U.S.-style liberal/conservative ideology (Thams), the "usual suspect" countries (Bruijn) and national-level host governments (Sun) are all treated as if they were the whole picture.
- **Levels of analysis are collapsed.** All four call for multi-level work: nation versus subculture (Caprar), home, host and supranational versus subsidiary and CEO (Thams, Sun), MNE, civil-society actor and country (Bruijn).
- **Society is an outcome, not only a setting.** The firm's effect on society is rarely measured (Bruijn), MNEs spread ideology (Thams), and nonmarket strategy's intent is usually inferred rather than observed (Sun).

Your line for class: *"All four papers make the same move from different directions: they show that what the field treated as a fixed backdrop, culture, ideology, civil society or institutions, is something MNEs act on and are acted on by, at several levels at once. That is a measurement problem as much as a theory problem."* It connects to your own paper: the field's conclusions depend on where and at what level it looks.

At a glance

	Caprar et al. 2022	Bruijn et al. 2024	Thams et al. 2025	Sun et al. 2021
Journal	JIBS 53: 1449–1483	JIBS 55: 136–156	JWB 60, 101678	JIBS 52: 1818–1853
Type	Review + theory building	Systematic review	Conceptual perspective	Systematic review
Evidence	95 empirical studies, 23 journals, 1980–2020	166 articles, 41 journals, 1990–2020	No data	367 articles, 44 journals, 2000–2020
Question	When do countercultural practices work?	What do we know about MNE–civil society interactions?	How does political ideology shape MNEs?	How do MNEs use nonmarket strategy across institutions?
Big claim	Fit is not always good	Research is out of step with practice	IB is the right home for ideology research	Subnational and micro levels are missing
Signature evidence	Rabl et al.: HPWS stronger in high power distance	GDELT: US, China, India over-studied	Fig. 1: context → mechanisms → impacts, with	Table 2: 4 host-subnational studies, none home-

			feedback	subnational
Note		First author is Bruijn (file name misspells it)	Newburry is 5th author	Institutional theory in 125 of 323

1 · Caprar, Kim, Walker & Caligiuri (2022). Beyond "Doing as the Romans Do": A review of research on countercultural business practices. JIBS, 53, 1449–1483.

Question. When and why can business practices that do not match local culture be effective or welcomed (pp. 1449, 1473)?

Gap. Fit between practice and culture is treated as "almost axiomatic" (p. 1460); countercultural practice is cast as failure and contrary findings as "anomalies" (p. 1450). The authors "problematize" that assumption (pp. 1451, 1459) without disputing the value of adaptation.

Key terms. *Countercultural practices*: "practices that are seemingly incongruent with local cultural norms or values" (p. 1449). *Fit*: "consistency between business practices (broadly defined) and local cultures" (p. 1460). *Cultural adaptation imperative*: the assumption "that fit is inherently beneficial" (p. 1459). Also: advantage of foreignness, liability of localness (p. 1467), crossvergence (p. 1461), reverse adaptation (p. 1472), cultural agility (p. 1473).

Theory. Foil theories that built the fit preoccupation: population ecology, contingency, institutional theory, liability of foreignness (p. 1460). Culture models: Hofstede, GLOBE "as is"/"should be", tightness–looseness (p. 1469). Constructive lenses: problematization, positive cross-cultural scholarship, self-determination theory, RBV and differentiation.

Method. Scoping phase, then a keyword search of 23 journals, 1980–2020 (p. 1452). 95 empirical studies: 22 on benefits, 18 on acceptance, 14 on negative outcomes of local practices, 41 related (pp. 1452, 1455).

Findings.

- Benefits in leadership style, HR systems and culture/climate; HPWS effects stronger in high power-distance and collectivist countries (pp. 1463–1464).
- Acceptance: collectivist employees often prefer individual rewards; high power-distance employees welcome voice (pp. 1465–1466).
- Rejection of local practices: guanxi-based HRM, jeitinho, nepotism (p. 1466).
- Four explanations (Fig. 2, p. 1468): **ontological** (culture is looser and more varied than national profiles; desired versus actual values), **epistemological** (researchers expected fit; dichotomous standardize-or-localize logic), **causal** (culture is not always the cause; practices can reshape culture), **functional** (misfit as strategic differentiation).
- Agenda: strategic intent, local preferences, institutional drivers, social responsibility (pp. 1473–1475).

Limitations. Cultural lens only (p. 1451); file-drawer bias (p. 1455); mostly individual-level, mostly national samples (pp. 1470, 1473). *Small inconsistency: Rabl et al. is 56 effect sizes in Table 1 (p. 1455) but 159 studies in the text (p. 1464).*

Quotes. "under certain conditions, countercultural practices *can be* effective" (p. 1465) · "practices that are in fact a good fit with a particular (sub)culture are incorrectly cast as 'countercultural', a label rendered by researchers' overly blunt assumptions about the default culture of their study's participants" (p. 1470) · "it does not prescribe adaptation by default" (p. 1476).

Link to your work. Samples come from "specific geographic areas, occupations, industries, organizations" (p. 1470): an auditor panel is an occupational subculture, which supports bounding by region and measuring variation within it. The epistemological explanation, researchers primed by fit reading disconfirming results as anomalies, is a field-level version of confirmation (a stretch, but a good class point). *Newburry co-authored Chen et al. (2017), cited in Table 3.*

Likely questions.

- *Why were countercultural practices unstudied?* The field's core theories made fit axiomatic, and early recommendations to adapt turned contrary results into anomalies (pp. 1450, 1460, 1462).
- *Does this license cultural imperialism?* No: the authors reject that and centre local employees' needs "as defined by themselves" (pp. 1451, 1475).

2 · Bruijn, Georgallis, Albino-Pimentel, Kourula & Teegen (2024). MNE–civil society interactions: A systematic review and research agenda. JIBS, 55, 136–156.

Question. What do we know about the nature, context, antecedents, outcomes and moderators of MNE–civil society interactions, and what should IB do next (pp. 136–137)?

Gap. The literature is spread across six disciplines, and scholars risk "an incomplete understanding of the same 'elephant'" (p. 137); few link IB theory to neighbouring fields.

Key terms. *Civil society:* "an area of organization, separate from both the state and the market, where individuals coalesce to take sustained action in pursuit of common interests" (p. 136); three elements, a separate sector, collective action and endurance, so one-off protests are excluded (p. 138). *Interaction:* a relational action by one actor directed at the other (p. 140), conflictual (boycotts, protests) or cooperative (donations, collaborations). *Institutional resonance* (p. 145), *social license to operate* (p. 145), *astroturfing* (p. 146), *moral markets* (p. 152).

Method. Scopus and Web of Science, five journal categories, 1990–2020; 1,372 hits cut to **166 articles in 41 journals**; strict inclusion: an MNE, a civil-society actor and a relational action (pp. 137, 139). 109 empirical articles coded: 73.4% qualitative, 22.9% quantitative, 3.7% mixed (pp. 140–142). **Benchmark against practice using GDELT event data** (p. 143).

Theory mix (Table 2, p. 142). Institutional 18.2%, stakeholder 15.3%, sociological 11.3%, strategy 8.4%, political science 7.9%, **IB only 5.4%**, no explicit theory 17.7%.

Findings.

- Growth after 2008; two-thirds in 2010–2020 (p. 141).
- Conflict and cooperation studied about equally; 8% study both (p. 142).
- Host country in about 52%; developing economies 61.2%; raw materials, consumer, food and energy; environment 52.3%, labour 33.9% (p. 143).

- **US, China and India over-studied; Canada, Chile and Indonesia under-studied relative to GDELT** (pp. 143–144).
- Antecedents of conflict: societal impact, prominence, weak institutional resonance; of cooperation: legitimacy and resource needs, risk management (pp. 144–145).
- Societal outcomes rarely measured (pp. 145–146).

Agenda (Table 3, p. 149). Broaden contexts; country-level institutional and cultural antecedents; MNE learning and the time limits of legitimacy; societal outcomes. Proposed IB lenses: CSA/FSA, liability of foreignness, the bargaining model, integration–responsiveness (pp. 150–152).

Quotes. "an incomplete understanding of the same 'elephant'" (p. 137) · "the interactions examined in the reviewed literature are not fully representative of actual interactions in practice (data from GDELT), which suggests conscious or unconscious bias in authors' selections of sites" (p. 143) · "expand the contexts studied beyond the 'usual suspect' countries" (p. 150).

Link to your work (strongest of the four). The GDELT check compares where research samples against where the phenomenon actually occurs. That is the same test as your H3: stated versus achieved coverage. Cite it next to Lopez, Kundu and Ciravegna.

Likely questions.

- *Why is the conflict explanation "rather narrow"?* Studies trace conflict to MNE harm, but activists "do not always target the most egregious offenders" (p. 148); the authors propose institutional and cultural antecedents (pp. 150–151).
- *Why so little IB theory?* IB is "very self-reliant and self-referencing" (p. 148); recast civil-society ties as firm-specific advantages, offsets to liability of foreignness, or a party in the bargaining model (pp. 151–152).

3 · Thams, Dau, Doh, Kostova & Newbury (2025). Political ideology and the multinational enterprise: Broadening the epistemological lens. Journal of World Business, 60, 101678.

Newbury is fifth author; Dau is the corresponding author (p. 1). Expect him to test whether you read it closely.

Question. How does political ideology form and play out inside MNEs and their settings, and how does it shape strategy, operations and social impact (p. 1)?

Gap. Ideology research is "largely under-contextualized", U.S.-centric and tied to the liberal/conservative spectrum; it ignores the many ideological forces MNEs face; and there is "minimal work that presents a rigorous theoretical foundation" (pp. 2–3).

Key terms. *Political ideology*: "widely shared and deeply held beliefs regarding how a society ought to be structured" (p. 2). *Organizational political ideology*: "an enduring and lasting set of political beliefs and worldviews" held by members (p. 5). *Multiplicity, relationality, dynamism* (from Eden & Nielsen, p. 5). *Ideological congruence/incongruence* (p. 7). *MNEs as ideological agents*, "vehicles for the diffusion of political ideologies" (p. 6).

Theory. Weber and Marx on ideology (p. 1); motivated cognition and the logic of appropriateness (p. 3); Attraction-Selection-Attrition (p. 5). Applied to institutional theory, resource dependence, RBV/VRIO

(Patagonia), knowledge-based view, TCE and internalization ("double-edged sword") and upper echelons (pp. 7–9). The "epistemological lens" is a call to relax the rational-actor view and borrow from political science (p. 9).

Method. Conceptual perspective; "No data was used" (p. 9).

Framework (Fig. 1, p. 8). *Context* (levels from supranational to founder; dimensions liberal/conservative, left/right, socialism/capitalism, democracy/autocracy, tight/loose, congruence, homogeneous/diverse) → *Mechanisms* (cognitive biases, risk perception, information processing, identity, compliance, legitimacy, values, goals) → *Impacts* (market and nonmarket strategy, internal organization, social impact), with a **feedback arrow from impacts back to context**, which is what "reflexive" means.

Five insights (pp. 5, 7). Differentiate the concept beyond the U.S.; match the level to the question; study the multiple ideologies MNEs carry; go beyond economic models of internationalization; study societal as well as strategic impact.

Measurement problem (p. 7). Countries are measured categorically (parties) and executives continuously (donations); fixes include rescaling, factor-analytic indices and content analysis of "tone".

Quotes. "managing in the context of an MNE is not ideologically neutral" (p. 7) · "research in this realm is largely under-contextualized" (p. 2) · ideology "can provide a 'double-edged sword': it can benefit or cost companies" (p. 9).

Link to your work. Chin et al. (2021) adapted a U.S.-validated survey for Iran and it still missed local factors (p. 4): measurement equivalence across cultures, your H5 territory. Piurko et al.: "right" and "left" cohere in liberal and traditional countries but not post-communist ones (p. 4), support for bounding by institutional cluster. The paper lists ideology as "a form of cognitive bias" (p. 1): a parallel to prior beliefs filtering judgment, but a stretch for audit.

Likely questions from a co-author.

- *Why is IB the right home?* It is comparative and cross-national, and MNEs face multiplicity, relationality and dynamism across home, host and supranational contexts (pp. 2, 5).
- *What does "reflexive" mean in Fig. 1?* Impacts feed back into context: MNEs spread values across borders (pp. 6, 8).
- *How does ideology challenge internalization theory?* Those theories assume profit-maximizers; U.S. MNEs leaving Russia on CEO ideology show ideology cutting against the bottom line (pp. 8–9).
- *What blocks the study of incongruence, and the fix?* Mismatched measures across levels; rescale, build indices, or content-analyze texts (p. 7).

4 · Sun, Doh, Rajwani & Siegel (2021). Navigating cross-border institutional complexity: A review and assessment of multinational nonmarket strategy research. JIBS, 52, 1818–1853.

Question. What has 2000–2020 research established about how MNEs use nonmarket strategy across home, host and supranational institutions, and where next (pp. 1818–1819)?

Gap. No systematic assessment of NMS "with reference to the IB field in general and to the MNE in particular" (p. 1819); only 18 of Mellahi et al.'s 214 articles overlap, so NMS research leans single-country (p. 1823).

Key terms. *Nonmarket strategy*: "a firm's concerted action to improve its competitive position and performance by actively managing the institutional or societal contexts of business competition in which it operates", made of CPA and strategic CSR and unfolding at several levels (p. 1818). *Institutional multiplicity* (p. 1824). *Obsolescing bargaining model* (p. 1828). *Political capabilities* (p. 1830). *Cross-border institutional capabilities* (pp. 1837–1838).

Method. EBSCO, 44 journals, 2000–2020, **367 articles**; cross-border or comparative only; nonmarket variables must be DV, IV or moderator, not controls (p. 1820). Coding cross-checked by two authors (p. 1821).

Theory mix. Institutional theory in 125 of 323 articles (pp. 1823–1824); then RBV 37, stakeholder 32, resource dependence 30, IB-based 33.

Findings.

- 273 articles in 2011–2020 against 94 in 2001–2010; JIBS alone 20% (pp. 1822–1823).
- 173 CPA, 141 SCSR, 53 both; 56% quantitative (p. 1823).
- China in more than a quarter of empirical studies (p. 1823).
- **Levels (Table 2, p. 1825): 110 host-national only, 52 home-national only, 4 host-subnational only, 0 home-subnational only**, 66 home–host, 62 supranational.
- HQ–subsidiary and TMT research "still in its infancy" (p. 1832); CPA–SCSR integration under 20% and "extremely limited" (pp. 1837, 1841).

Agenda (Table 6, p. 1841). Micro-level processes (discourse methods); global macro institutions (multilevel methods); CPA–SCSR as complements or substitutes (difference-in-differences, cases); multi-actor issues (social network analysis).

Quotes. "The preponderance of SCSR research in this area does not observe nor measure the actual nonmarket strategies of firms; rather, the strategic intent of these actions is inferred or imputed" (p. 1835) · "We saw no explicit attempts to incorporate individual-level factors such as managerial cognition into the bargaining models" (p. 1829) · "microlevel research has been particularly underrepresented" (p. 1842).

Link to your work. Table 2 is a ready citation for stating the institutional level at which a design is bounded and not treating "country" as the only unit (p. 1825); the call for multilevel methods across "supranational, regional, national, and local" levels (p. 1844) supports your nesting. The missing managerial-cognition point (p. 1829) supports your judgment-level research in general terms.

Likely questions.

- *Why does institutional theory dominate?* The institutional lens is "intrinsic to the international aims" of this literature (pp. 1823–1824).
- *Are CPA and SCSR complements or substitutes?* Mostly complements: SCSR buys legitimacy with political actors (p. 1839), but host-country CPA can clash with home expectations, as with Google and Yahoo in China (pp. 1839, 1845).

Cross-paper questions Newburry may ask

- "Which of these would you use to justify a multi-country design, and why?" Sun for the levels (Table 2), Bruijn for site selection versus practice (GDELT), Caprar for subculture versus nation.
- "Ideology (Thams) and culture (Caprar): same thing?" No. Ideology is beliefs about how society *ought* to be structured (Thams, p. 2); culture is shared values and norms. Both are multi-level and both are over-read from national averages.
- "Where do civil society (Bruijn) and nonmarket strategy (Sun) overlap?" SCSR and NGO engagement; Sun's NGOs/supply chains/human rights stream is Bruijn's cooperative interaction seen from the firm's side.
- "What would a study that answers all four look like?" Multi-level, outside the usual-suspect countries, measuring societal outcomes as well as firm outcomes, with culture and ideology measured below the nation.

NotebookLM: how to load this

I cannot open NotebookLM or upload to it; it has no connection available here. Five minutes by hand:

- Go to notebooklm.google.com, **New notebook**, name it *GEB 7365 · MNE beyond the market*.
- **Add sources:** the four PDFs (Caprar, Bruijn, Thams, Sun) and this file

(READINGS_NONMARKET_STUDY_PACK.pdf).

- **Audio Overview** → **Customize**, paste:

> Two hosts discuss four papers for a doctoral international business seminar taught by William > Newburry, who co-authored Thams et al. (2025). Explain each paper's question, method and main > finding, then the thread across all four: context, levels of analysis and societal outcomes. > Spend extra time on Thams et al.'s Figure 1 and on Bruijn et al.'s GDELT comparison. 15 minutes.

- **Chat prompts to paste:**
- "Quiz me with 10 questions across the four papers, one at a time, and grade my answers against the text with page numbers."
- "What would Professor Newburry most likely ask about Thams et al. (2025)? Give me model answers from the paper."
- "Build a table comparing the four papers on question, method, sample, theory and main finding."
- "Which claims in these papers could I cite to argue that multi-country research samples are regionally concentrated?"
- **Check any page number NotebookLM gives you against the PDF** before you use it in class.